

Safe browsing refers to the practices and behaviours that help users navigate the internet securely while reducing the risk of exposure to cyber threats. Since many attacks originate from websites, links, and online interactions, understanding how to browse safely is an essential part of overall cyber security for both individuals and organisations.

The internet is a primary source of information, communication, and services, but it is also a common delivery channel for threats such as phishing, malware, and social engineering attacks. Malicious websites can appear legitimate, making it difficult to distinguish between safe and unsafe sources without careful evaluation.

Safe browsing involves being aware of how websites are accessed, how content is delivered, and how trust is established online. Attackers often rely on users clicking links without verification or downloading content from untrusted sources. In many cases, compromised or fake websites are designed to closely resemble legitimate ones in order to deceive users.

There are several common risks associated with unsafe browsing:

- Visiting malicious or compromised websites that host malware
- Clicking on deceptive links that redirect to fake login pages
- Downloading files from unverified or untrusted sources
- Encountering drive-by downloads that install software without consent
- Exposure to tracking scripts or data collection without awareness

These risks highlight the importance of evaluating websites and links before interacting with them.

Recognising potentially unsafe websites is a key aspect of safe browsing. Indicators may include:

- Unusual or misspelled domain names that resemble legitimate sites
- Missing or invalid security certificates (e.g. lack of HTTPS)
- Unexpected pop-ups or redirects
- Requests for sensitive information without clear justification
- Poor website design or inconsistent branding compared to known legitimate sources
- Suspicious links shared via email, messages, or social media

While none of these signs alone confirm malicious intent, they can help identify situations where additional caution is required.

Protecting against browsing-related threats involves adopting safe and consistent habits:

- Accessing websites directly by typing known URLs rather than clicking unknown links
- Verifying the authenticity of websites before entering sensitive information
- Avoiding downloads from unfamiliar or untrusted sources
- Keeping browsers and plugins updated to reduce vulnerabilities
- Using security features such as built-in phishing and malware protection
- Reviewing browser permissions and limiting unnecessary access
- Logging out of accounts after use, especially on shared devices

For organisations, safe browsing practices are often supported through additional controls such as web filtering, endpoint protection, and security policies that restrict access to known malicious or unverified sites. Employee awareness and training also play an important role in reducing the likelihood of successful attacks.

Safe browsing is not only about avoiding obvious threats, but also about developing a cautious approach to interacting with online content. As attackers continue to evolve their techniques, maintaining awareness and applying verification steps can significantly reduce exposure to risk.

This page provides an overview of safe browsing principles and common risks associated with internet use. By understanding how threats are delivered through websites and online interactions, users can better protect themselves while navigating the web.